

Nah.

If you really want to raise generous, grateful kids, a song won't do it.

You need to get their hands dirty.

Yet that was a lesson I wouldn't end up learning for real until nearly a decade after 'We Are the World', when a chance meeting changed my life.

The experience of a lifetime

My teenage years weren't my happiest.

Like most teenagers, the world revolved around me and my problems, and the injustice of how hard my life was. (I discovered girls, though they didn't discover me till many, many years later.)

One day my English teacher, Mr Ellison, gave us an assignment to write about someone else's life.

Meh.

I was thinking about who I'd write about as I walked home from school . . . past an old people's home.

A flash of inspiration hit me!

So I walked into the home, barrelled up to the front desk, and announced to one of the nurses:

'I'd like to interview someone really old.'

My 13-year-old logic was this: if I had to pad out an essay, I'd write about the oldest bugger I could find.

The nurses didn't disappoint. They introduced me to Jack, a man in his 90s.

There was a single black-and-white photo on the bedside table in Jack's room, and he was sitting with his back to us, staring out the window, when the nurse led me in. He didn't hear us, so one of the nurses yelled out to him, even though he was only a few metres away:

'JACK! YOU HAVE A VISITOR!'